From a First Question to a Page the Family Can Return To

An unhurried plan for talking about care wishes: nine actions, in order, with a line for who does each.

The goal: what your wife wants to keep is written down in her words, what each of you could honestly offer is written beside it, and the questions nobody could answer are still on the page.

There's no deadline on any of it. It can take a month or a season. Put a name next to each action, add a date only if a date helps, and tick it when it's done.

ACTION	WHO	WHEN	DONE
1. Ask your wife whether she'd be willing to talk about the future. If she says “not today,” pause here until she's ready.			
2. Ask her what matters most to her, starting with a good day and her ordinary routines, not with anything that might change.			
3. Write down the routines and choices she wants to keep, in her own words, the same day if you can.			
4. Read what you wrote back to her and ask whether you got it right. Change whatever she corrects.			
5. Ask each of the kids, and anyone else who would be involved, what they hope for and what concerns them.			
6. Ask each of them, and yourself, what you could realistically offer, how often, and what it depends on. Write down what each person couldn't do as well.			
7. Keep her wishes and the family's hopes on separate parts of the page, and note where two people expect different things. Write both; settle neither.			
8. List the questions nobody in the family could answer. Next to each, write who it might go to: her doctor, another professional, or your care consultant.			
9. Agree together, your wife included, how you'll come back to this page as life changes.			

You're done when

Her wishes are written down in her words and she has seen them, what each person could offer is written beside them, the unanswered questions are still on the page, and you've agreed how you'll keep the conversation going. Working out what the family would weigh if a choice ever came up isn't on this list, and neither is any decision about care. Those aren't the family's to do alone, and nothing here calls for them.

If it doesn't go in order

- If she'd rather not talk about it, that's her answer for now. The rest of the list will keep.
- If one of the kids offers less than you'd hoped, write down what they did offer. An honest “I can't” belongs on the page as much as a yes.
- Don't fill a quiet spot with a guess. “Haven't asked yet” is a complete entry.

What this plan doesn't do

It puts the family's conversations in order. It doesn't say whether your wife needs anything, weigh whether the family's offers would be enough, or certify anything about her health or safety. The page you end with is a starting point to return to, not a plan for her care.

Ready for the next step?

You've taken the conversations one at a time and ended with a page the family can return to. The care interview builds on that page: it walks through your wife's situation area by area, so nothing important is left to memory, and turns your answers into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

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